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Conversations on Cultural Heritage: Confirming the Family Home as an Archive

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Introduction

Preserving family home archives is crucial for safeguarding the rich tapestry of stories, traditions, and memories that comprise our cultural heritage and individual histories. As time passes and family members age, recalling memories can become increasingly challenging, making it vital to preserve our family histories to ensure they are not lost to time. The connection between how individual families maintain their “archives” through generations is central to this discussion. Using an autoethnographic approach, this paper documents the authors' lived experiences surrounding family records within the heart of their homes.

The researchers explore their experiences through conversational engagements, focusing on themes such as creating archives and collections and their diverse functions, including symbolic value, legitimization, and documentation of previously untold histories. Additionally, the paper examines how unique information-gathering practices inform multi-generational literacy practices. Of particular interest is how family stories may remain constant even as narrators change over time, impacting family histories within the home.

This paper investigates how family home archives provide evidence for survival, acceptance, and belonging. Heirlooms, keepsakes, and photographs can signify the existence of life, relationships, and witnessing of historical events. These conversations offer researchers deeper insights into memories, traditions, and cultural identity. The analysis examines these practices through self-reflection, addressing the need for a deeper understanding of cultural heritage and human experience throughout our lifetime. The focus is on personal histories within broader historical contexts, emphasizing the urgency and importance of this research.

Theoretical Framework

Our research is grounded in the work of several scholars specializing in the documentation of personal and family archives. We have integrated concepts in personal archiving and the theory of home as a repository. Specifically, our paper draws from Sutherland’s (2023) stance on the “right to be forgotten” (RTBF) and the choice of what is shared and what is kept private. Balancing individual privacy with public access to information is a longstanding issue within archival circles, predating the current RTBF debate (Vavra, 2018). The idea of the home as a family archive conveys how people curate and preserve their personal spaces and experiences. At home, certain items are displayed (e.g., family photos) while others are kept private (like personal diaries). Sutherland's (2023) RTBF model is comparable to the ability to "redecorate" your home and decide which memories or personal information are on display and which are tucked away. The discourse around RTBF and public access parallels the idea of a family home serving dual

roles: a private space for daily life and a sacred space for preserving personal history. Archivists and librarians advocating for public access to information can be seen as supporting the family's archive as an accessible space. Simultaneously, the RTBF emphasizes the family's right to control the home as a suite of private 'rooms.'

We connect the Right to Be Forgotten (RTBF) framework to archival appraisal theory. The theoretical discussion surrounding RTBF and public access to information mirrors the dual roles of a family home as a private space for daily life and a sacred space for preserving personal history. This duality reflects the balance that archivists and librarians strive to achieve, advocating for public access to information while respecting individual privacy rights.

Archival appraisal theory is essential in this context (Duranti, 1994), as it provides the principles and methodologies for determining which records should be preserved for public access and which should remain private. Applying these appraisal principles, we argue that families, like professional archivists, must decide which aspects of their personal histories are shared with the public and which are kept within the family home.

In its access to information laws, UNESCO discusses the right to seek, receive, and impart information held by public bodies. This resource establishes an international understanding that frames these rights as fundamental to freedom of expression. In this context, the RTBF framework emphasizes a family's right to control their home as a series of private 'rooms,' paralleling the archival practice of designating certain records as private or restricted. This analogy strengthens our theoretical framework and underscores the practical implications of archival appraisal theory about personal and family archives.

We further expand on the frameworks Narayan et al. (2024) used to examine family stories and life histories, typically shared among household members through various information practices such as oral and written communication, family traditions, and personal preservation techniques across generations. We explore these practices by engaging in conversations and understanding how we enact information behaviors for gathering and preserving personal and family history. This process occurs within the family home, conceptualized as the family archive.

The theory of the family archive, as presented by Woodham et al. (2017), centers our research on the home as a repository of family memories and histories. To complement our framework, we also consider Wilson's (1999) Information-Seeking Behavior Model, which aims to understand how people seek, use, and share information within the family archive. By applying Wilson's model to families, we seek insights into the dynamic process of information behavior within families,

highlighting how each stage—from identifying needs to sharing information— to preserving and evolving family archives within the home.

Collective Memory Theory (Halbwachs & Coser, 1992) explores how families collectively remember and transmit their histories. For example, how individuals become attached to objects is deeply intertwined with the home as an archive concept. Just as archives preserve documents and artifacts that embody memories and historical significance, the objects within our homes serve as tangible records of our personal and collective histories. This attachment to objects stems from their ability to encapsulate moments, people, and experiences.

Vygotsky's Sociocultural Theory (1978) aids us in understanding the role of intergenerational social interaction in developing and preserving family histories. The passing down of stories, memories, and experiences within a family is vital for transmitting cultural knowledge and fostering a strong sense of identity across generations. Family members absorb and internalize this information through interactions with elders with more experience and wisdom. Vygotsky calls this learning exchange the "zone of proximal development" (p. 90), where one's independent learning is enhanced by elderly guidance and familial collaboration.

Our research integrates these theories to comprehensively understand the home as a personal family archive in a place-based environment. We aim to balance the importance of preserving and sharing family histories with the need for privacy. By systematically applying these theories to our research, we hope to gain deeper insights into the practices and dynamics involved in curating family home archives.

Literature Review

In recent years, the concept of the home archive has gained significant attention within archival studies, primarily due to its profound connection to memory and identity. As spaces where personal memories and collective histories converge, home archives serve as living repositories that shape and reflect individual and familial identities. This literature review explores the nature of home archives, examining them through the lenses of generational and cultural differences and exploring their role as spaces and places that encapsulate the evolving narrative of families.

We first discuss the home archive as a memoir of identity, highlighting how personal artifacts, letters, and photographs collected within domestic spaces contribute to constructing and perpetuating self and family narratives. These materials are tangible embodiments of memories, anchoring identity into our physical world.

This concise review seeks to illuminate the significance of home archives as repositories of personal history and vital components of cultural heritage and identity, offering new insights into the interplay between memory, identity, and place.

Home as Space: The Home as an Archive of Memoir and Identity

The home archive plays a crucial role in understanding the value of material possessions and their crucial role in shaping identity. Eire (2011) discusses how family stories evolve and how changing narrators affect family histories. Eire's 2011 memoir, *Learning to Die in Miami: Confessions of a Refugee Boy,* explores his experiences as a young Cuban refugee adjusting to life in Miami, highlighting the impact of family history and personal narratives on his identity. His stories remind us that narrators change, and the interpretation and emphasis of family stories within the home archive can shift, reflecting each storyteller's personal experiences and cultural contexts. This evolution can change how family histories are perceived and remembered across generations and cultures. This also plays a significant role in how the family home archive is structured and sustained, and it gives us a better understanding of the family home as a physical space and an archive where stories and experiences are passed down through generations. Each generation contributes its layer, influencing how the collective family history is remembered and valued.

As family members who serve as caretakers or narrators of the family's story change, their unique perspectives reshape the "archive" within the home, similar to how we redecorate or rearrange a house over time. The material possessions, like heirlooms, are imbued with stories that evolve with each storyteller's personal and cultural context, just like how a family home holds memories that shift over generations. So, the family home as an archive is not static; it breathes and changes with every new narrator and story over time. The "right to be forgotten" can be linked to deciding what parts of the home's history are kept visible and which are tucked away aligns with Sutherland's (2023) RTBF concept.

The concept of a family home as an archive is deeply entwined with evolving narratives that reflect generational and cultural shifts and help form a family's identity. Older generations might emphasize tales of survival and resilience to document their historical challenges, while younger generations often highlight personal achievements and modern values. Narratives differ significantly through generations and cultures. Cultural backgrounds also influence these narratives, with some cultures placing a higher value on collective memory and others on individual experiences.

Dunbar et al. (2024) emphasize the centrality of culture's impact on lived experience in exploring critical information behavior through the lens of

autoethnographic BIPOC identity heritage research. They highlight how personal and community histories inform individuals' understanding of their identity and heritage. Dunbar et al. (2024) state that when Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (BIPOC) individuals examine their own experiences and those of their communities, they can gain deeper insights into the profundity of their historical and cultural backgrounds. By examining their experiences and communities, BIPOC individuals create a living archive within their personal and community spaces. This autoethnographic process is similar to how family homes become repositories of evolving narratives, reflecting individual and collective histories. Both perspectives emphasize the importance of personal stories and community context in shaping and preserving cultural identity.

Home as Place: The Family as an Archive of Memory and History

The concept of home extends beyond a physical space to encompass a repository of family memories and histories. We take a closer look at place theory through the work of McKittrick (2006), who uses geographic inquiry to explore how the home serves as a family history archive. Santos (1978; 2001) applies central place theory to understand the significance of home in maintaining and transmitting family narratives. These perspectives underscore the importance of home as a central place for preserving and sharing family stories.

Bastian (2003) explores the idea of a house of memory, where the archivist holds the key. The house of memory is known as a repository or space housing records, manuscripts, and memorabilia of our shared pasts. Bastian states that when memory attaches to these spaces, "they transform into powerful, self-referencing contexts for collective memory, serving as overarching environments that knit together the contents into a coherent narrative" (p. 1). In this same vein, Trace (2024) explores the concept of home archives by challenging traditional archival provenance, which typically centers on limited relationships like individuals, families, or organizations. Trace expands on the theoretical and practical aspects of linking archival boundaries to functions and activities that reflect domestic spaces and relationships. This literature review highlights a substantial body of work questioning key archival control concepts and offering new interpretations that merge the concept of archives with that of the family home. This dynamic view acknowledges that as families grow and evolve, their sense of home evolves, reflecting these changes within the archival space. For instance, family narratives in immigrant families often center around migration, cultural adaptation, and heritage preservation. Military families may focus on duty, sacrifice, and the impact of military life. Families may record their ancestors' roles in notable events to preserve memories with historical significance. These varied narratives highlight how family archives serve as evolving, rich tapestries of identity and legacy, reflecting each family's diverse experiences and cultural backgrounds.

This review helped us understand that generational and cultural differences shape how home archives are curated and interpreted. The members' varied experiences and cultural backgrounds enrich the narratives preserved within home archives, creating a tapestry of stories that illustrate the resilience and transformation of family identity across generations. Furthermore, the concept of home as a place of memory emphasizes the dynamic relationship between the physical space of the home and the archival contents it houses. As families grow and evolve, the narrative embedded within their home archive transforms, making it a powerful, living entity that captures the fluidity of family history and memory.

Research Questions

In exploring family histories and the concept of a family archive about the family home, there are notable gaps in the current research regarding the role of family archives in collecting, maintaining, and comprehending multigenerational literacies within the construct of a home. Our study aims to address these gaps by raising the following questions:

1. What constitutes a family home archive?
2. What role do family archives play in comprehending multigenerational literary practices within the family home or space?
    a. How do family archives facilitate the understanding and transmission of literary practices across generations?
3. What connections exist between family archives and cultural identity, traditions, memories, and sense of place?

Methodology

Our study utilizes a qualitative mixed-method approach that combines autoethnography and critical inquiry to examine family histories and the concept of a family archive within the home. We conducted an autoethnography that integrates autoethnographic research, writing, storytelling, and collaborative, reflective methods to link the autobiographical and personal aspects with broader cultural, social, and political contexts. We drew on the foundational works of Ellis Adams and Bochner (2011), who emphasize the importance of connecting personal experiences to broader cultural frameworks. Additionally, our approach aligns with the principles of critical inquiry within qualitative research, as discussed by Lester and Nusbaum (2021), positioning it as a reflective process.

The following themes guided our conversational engagements:

> *Creation of Archives and Collections:* We explored the diverse functions of archives and collections, including their symbolic value, legitimization, and

documentation of previously untold histories. We also examined how unique information-gathering practices inform multigenerational literacy practices.

Personal Narratives and Reflections: As information researchers, we drew on our extensive research experience, each contributing unique personal narratives, reflections, and observations. This approach allowed us to construct a shared understanding of our topic and harness stories' theoretical power, as Mitchell and Egudo (2003) noted.

By integrating these methods, we aimed to provide a comprehensive understanding of the role of family archives in collecting, maintaining, and comprehending multigenerational literacies within the family home.

Data Collection & Analysis

The data collection process began with the authors writing their narratives and answering research questions offline. They then engaged in a series of autoethnographic and critical inquiry sessions, participating in reflective conversations.

To analyze the autoethnographic data, the researchers employed thematic coding to examine their narratives and conversational engagements. Thematic coding focused on recurring topics, cultural themes, and notable occurrences across three rounds:

- Round One: The authors addressed the research questions offline.
- Round Two: They met in real-time via Microsoft Teams to share responses and identify major themes.
- Round Three: They met again to analyze these themes and any unexpected findings.

Throughout these rounds, the authors systematically addressed their research questions. They started with the first question, combining their responses and highlighting examples to illustrate their findings.

Results

In response to Research Question #1: *What constitutes a family archive?* our study revealed that the family archive contains diverse physical items such as photographs, letters, videos, books, recipes, and cherished heirlooms spanning multiple generations. Our reflections are based on our family archives and our understanding of the concept of a family archive. Our study employed personal and conceptual autoethnography to comprehensively analyze family archives

within the family home. Personal autoethnography focuses on the individual experiences and narratives of the authors. Conceptual autoethnography, on the other hand, extends beyond individual narratives to explore broader theoretical and cultural themes.

In this study, we examine the concept of the family archive not just as a collection of physical items but as the process that evolves with the family's history and cultural practices. We combine this with our understanding of the family archive as a home. The family archive encompasses oral and spiritual artifacts, serving as an enduring tangible and intangible representation of the family (Irvin et al., 2024). One of the authors reflected that,

> *The family Bible is one example of how the family archive is not transitory. Across cultures, the sacred text of the family, be it a Bible, the Koran, a corpus of literature, or technology, is an artifact where families keep records of life events such as births, marriages, graduations, and deaths. For example, in African American culture, this cumulative recordkeeping of the family Bible over generations brings the family's sacred text to the level of a family archive. For American descendants of enslaved Africans, a textual artifact such as the family Bible captures the lifetimes of the recordkeepers and the family members being recorded simultaneously.*

Through this example, we learn that the journey of re(reading) and (re)writing in a family's sacred text can be experienced as an emotional time travel, when text is read anew, and new connections are made that tighten the bonds of the tapestry of the family's narrative over time. This narrative, thus, becomes the family's documented heritage.

Family archives come in pieces and exist throughout the family's life and through those who continue to tell the story about pictures, spiritual objects, and family histories. When discussing the family archive and its transitory nature, we posit that it exists in different spaces, depending on who carries the family histories with them or to whom they have been passed. Although a family archive may have moving artifacts, it may become confined to more than one person either generationally (being passed down) or simultaneously, where multiple persons have custodianship over family knowledge. The family archive is operationalized when curators are willing to keep these histories for years.

For example, one of the authors shared that,

> *My paternal grandmother purchased a heart-shaped locket while living in the United States. Within it, she kept a photograph of me from when I was five years old. I did not realize the value this had for my grandmother until she passed away and the locket was passed on to me. The photograph appeared worn, and the silver locket had tarnished, but these physical*

> *changes indicated its use and the special place it held in my grandmother's heart.*

This example speaks to the physical family artifacts kept in familial archives, which can represent stories we do not know until they have been passed down. Often, families have artifacts, and their meaning is straightforward once the story is unified with the record that connects the narrative to the artifact. A lot can be said about this connecting factor, especially when understanding the emotional experience that can be felt when seeing and holding an artifact with a deeper meaning and connection to one's family.

The authors proceeded with answering Research Question #2:

> *What is the role of family archives in understanding multi-generational literacy practices within the family home or space?*

Their responses to this question indicated that the family archive's role in understanding multi-generational literacy practices encapsulates the family's histories; there are specific information behaviors and practices that tell the stories of lineage, love, and familial ties that transcend into the community. The fabric of the family archive is woven through the generations to which it is entrusted. This includes oral traditions such as storytelling, language, prayers, and music - intertwined with song and dance - and narratives encompassing life-affirming and trauma-informed generational experiences. Listening to oral histories and writing them down are distinct literacy practices that record selected life experiences, memories, and events. These practices are often multi-generational as family artifacts are bequeathed and passed down from generation to generation.

These traditions continue to evolve and endure as families expand and pass on their collective knowledge through shared moments, whether in celebration, gatherings, or poignant life events. This is when we witness the continuity of family legacies taking shape, with archival materials and records serving as vessels for the stories of life experiences carefully preserved in sacred spaces. The multigenerational literary practices within the family home change as some family histories pass on, and others live through the generations to share that knowledge with their children.

In considering the sub-question of Research Question #2, *How do family archives facilitate the understanding and transmission of literary practices across generations?,* the authors further acknowledged that the future of family literacies lies in the hands of their children and grandchildren, as the youth have a vital role in the family archive to ensure the legacy of the family archive; they are the hope for our stories to keep being told, for the memories to keep unfolding, and they take the family archive with them as their identity starts to form. Children grow up with the family archive inside the home, where family literacy practices start during

the early childhood years. Family narrative, history, and legacy are taught to us as early as we can see, hear, and taste.

The family archive preserves a family's memories and confirms their existence and humanity. The archive reveals ancestral literacy practices regarding the books family members possessed and what notes they may have left behind in those books, especially religious texts such as Bibles, the Koran, the Talmud, and the Vedas, to name a few. Recording life events in a sacred text is a prime example of a multi-generational literacy practice.

One of the authors states,

> *For example, my family's Bible currently has three generations of handwriting, which records six generations of oral history. The power of our family Bible as an artifact of the home archive or as an archive in and of itself is that collective recordkeeping demonstrates generations of committed devotional practices to shared narrated spaces. Family record keeping is a living body of knowledge that starts within family literacy practices and expands to tell the story of stories, beliefs, and life histories.*

The last question considered was Research Question #3:

> *What are the connections between family archives and cultural identity, traditions, memories, and place?*

The authors' responses captured several themes when answering this question, as they discussed how the family archives connect them to their cultural identity, traditions, memories, and sense of place. As an information practice, curating a family archive allows people to tell who they are, how they came into existence, and what their family members endured and achieved during their lifetimes. Family archives substantiate human knowledge, experience, and existence (Krtalić et al., 2021). A family archive solidifies a family's identity as a group that shares cultural practices, traditions, and understandings. In terms of memory, the family archive crystallizes memory as an affirmation of lives lived. The family archive documents a place as having a story, a narrative of events, and the passage of time.

Evidence of the family archive is only sometimes held in physical spaces, as a lot can happen over a family's lifetime. Members pass away, materials get lost, and family members may migrate, leaving personal effects behind while acquiring new artifacts that add to the family's story. Family record-keeping practices are not confined to one method; they live on in unique ways through storytelling and narrative, as family members become the keepers of the stories and experiences. One constant is the stories, narratives, and experiences shared from generation to generation.

Discussion

The analysis of autoethnographic and critical inquiry-based conversational engagements revealed several key themes. The researchers identified recurring topics, cultural themes, and significant occurrences through offline and real-time discussions. Three major themes were recognized:

Tangible Curation: The family home archive is typically curated by a family member responsible for preserving and organizing the family's memories, information, and histories.

A tangible family archive includes physical items such as photographs, letters, videos, books, recipes, cherished heirlooms, and spiritual artifacts. These items serve as tangible and enduring representations of the family, reflecting their needs, aspirations, and cherished activities.

Intangible Curation: The family archive holds a story within the artifacts maintained in the home. The authors witnessed how when various family members touched the same artifact (e.g., a hat owned by an ancestor), different memories were shared and woven together to create a new record for oral preservation via collective memory- and sense-making.

An intangible family archive includes stories, memories, prayers, and idioms such as, "We do it like this," "We say it like that," and "That's how we do!" These artifacts are often operationalized by tangible curation, adding context and depth to family identity, heritage, and legacy.

Shared provenance: Through this autoethnographic study, the authors recognized that family archives are often shared by more than one person, generationally or simultaneously, over time to retain the context, authenticity, and value of family research practices. For one author, the family archive was curated by her grandmother, who documented her enslaved grandparents' data from memory. Then, when the grandmother passed in 1961, the author's mother took on the curation and passed it to her daughter (the author) in 1995. Since then, the author has been the curator of the family archive (in the form of a Bible) to pass on to her children and grandchildren when the time comes. This is generational shared provenance. An example of intergenerational shared provenance is when multiple family members simultaneously share curation duties for the family archive over multiple home archives. For example, one author possesses the table to a dining set owned by her grandmother (who passed in 2005), while one cousin has the hutch, and another was bequeathed the chairs.

The authors' autoethnographic conversations highlighted the importance of preserving family history, the role of physical and intangible artifacts in maintaining family identity, and the intergenerational transmission of values and traditions. The analysis also uncovered exceptional occurrences, such as unique family traditions (e.g., shared provenance of furniture) or unexpected events that significantly impacted the family's narrative (e.g., intangible curation of stories connected to another family member's memory).

Conclusion

The study's findings revealed the significance of the family home archive in preserving and transmitting family history and identity. The curated collection of physical and intangible artifacts plays a crucial role in maintaining the family's ongoing narrative and fostering a sense of continuity across generations within the family home. This research illuminates the impact of family home archives on cultural heritage and personal histories by highlighting the dynamic relationship between physical space, memory, and identity.

The authors' collective narratives substantiate that the family home archive is usually curated by one or more family member(s) entrusted with preserving and curating the family's memories, information, and histories. This archive represents a physical space where tangible and intangible experiences are preserved, contributing to the ongoing narrative of our lives. It includes physical possessions that serve as extensions of ourselves and mirror our needs, aspirations, and cherished activities.

Often, the family archive is kept by very few family members because it comes with a big responsibility and requires work. Family archives do not just appear; they are collected, kept, and passed on, and this process changes with time and place—especially for families with histories that involve mass migrations and changes in community and living spaces.

The authors recognize the limitations of the autoethnographic approach used in this study. While this method offers profound, reflective insights and allows for personal engagement with the subject matter, it also comes with biases and is confined to the researchers' personal experiences. To overcome these limitations, future research could incorporate qualitative interviews with more members using other ethnographic methods to broaden the scope and depth of the findings.

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